

**Tactical triumph:** Mercedes and Russell (middle) outmanoeuvred Ferrari drivers Leclerc and Hamilton (in red) to take the win in the opening Grand Prix. AP

Ferrari's only bet was to hope its rival's tyres would fall off a cliff towards the end of the race. The plan never came to fruition as Russell took the honours at the chequered flag with his teammate behind him in second. Leclerc finished 12 seconds adrift — almost the exact time lost by not pitting under the VSC, with Hamilton less than a second behind. There is no certainty that the Ferraris had the pace to thwart their rival had they pitted early, but on an engine-intensive track, in a car that was almost half a second slower, it was their best bet to start the season with a win.

Elsewhere, four-time world champion Max Verstappen enjoyed a positive race after crashing out of qualifying, cruising through the pack on an alternate strategy. The Dutch driver discarded the pre-decided plan under VSC conditions, opting for a two-stopper, which helped him finish sixth, just behind reigning champion Lando Norris, who had a largely uneventful race and was well off the pace compared to the top two teams.

Arvid Lindblad, the only rookie on the roster, enjoyed an impressive maiden race, finishing eighth for Racing Bulls. Home favourite Oscar Piastri crashed on his way to the grid in an unfortunate incident that extended the circuit's curse on Aussie drivers. Aston Martin, in the news for its struggles with heavy vibrations, left with just a participation certificate to show from the season opener.

There was far more action on the track compared to previous years, although almost all overtaking stemmed from residual battery power. After Race 1, one thing is certain about the 2026 regulations: the drivers' intellect will play as much of a role as the raw speed they possess.



## MotoGP



The opening race of the MotoGP season was Aprilia's to savour. The Italian manufacturer locked out four of the top five places at the Thai Grand Prix, with factory rider Marco Bezzecchi (**right**) taking home the win under scorching conditions. His teammate Jorge Martin, who has been blighted by injuries since his 2024 triumph, came home fourth. The Spaniard split Trackhouse Racing's Raul Fernandez (third) and Ai Ogura. Defending champion Marc Marquez was forced to retire a few laps from the end after aggressive kerb riding caused a puncture on his rear tyre.

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